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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Thursday, February 19, 2026

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[00:26:43] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings,

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[00:33:29] The Senate will come to order.

[00:37:31] The senators will please take their seats, those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance will please stand if you're able. We will be led in prayer today by Imam Kamran Shaikh from the West End Islamic Center in Glenallen.

[00:37:51] And following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing. We will be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by senate page davion harris of portsmouth asalaam alaikum warahmatullahi wabarakatuhu i offer you the peace and blessings of of islamic greetings bismillah rahman rahim in the name of our lord the most merciful i read a translation of one of the words of the quran oh people behold we have

[00:38:29] created you all out of male and a female and have made you into nations and tribes so that you might come to know one another. Verily, the noblest of you in the sight of God Almighty is the one who is most deeply conscious of him.

[00:38:46] Behold, Almighty God is all-knowing, all-aware.

[00:39:07] All praises belong to Allah Subh'anaHu Wa Ta-A'la, the most merciful, the abundantly merciful, owner of the Day of Judgment, only you we worship and only you we seek help from.

[00:39:25] Guide us to the straight path, the path of those who you have bestowed your mercy and favors on, not of those who have evoked your anger and went astray. We ask Lord Almighty to give us the wisdom to work towards the justice and to work for the truth.

[00:39:51] And we ask God to give us the strength to stand by the truth and by the side of the justice. Amen. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, One nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:40:40] This is the senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[00:41:03] I will suspend the rules that grant the privileges of the floor to certain distinguished persons. The question is, shall the rules be suspended as a privileged person? All in favor of that motion will record their votes.

[00:41:20] Aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 38, no zero. I'm sorry, Madam President, you have a quorum.

[00:41:40] 36, confusing morning. Ayes 38, no zero. Ayes 38, no zero. The rules are suspended. The privileges of the floor are granted. Now is the time for the swearing-in of Senator-elect Elizabeth B. Bennett Parker.

[00:42:02] The clerk will report an announcement. The senator-elect has been certified by the Department of Elections. Raise my right hand and put my...

[00:42:28] Raise my hand in the Bible now. Yeah. Yeah. I am a great way, isn't it? Right hand up. Okay. If you will raise your right hand, left hand on the bottom, and repeat after me.

[00:42:50] I do solemnly swear... I do solemnly swear... That I will support the Constitution of the United States... That I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge, and I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me, all the duties incumbent upon me, as a member of the Senate of Virginia, as a member of the Senate of Virginia, according to the best of my ability, according to the best of my ability, so help me God.

[00:43:22] So help me God. Congratulations. Thank you.

[00:43:25] the Senate will be briefly at ease so that our members may congratulate our

[00:45:07] new colleague that will return to order the clerk will call the roll all those

[00:52:59] present please vote aye the clerk will close the roll you have a quorum madam president Senate journal for Wednesday February 18th 2026 our new senator from

[00:53:32] Alexandria moves that the reading of the journal be waived all in favor all in favor of waiving the reading of that journal will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll eyes 33 knows five eyes 33 knows five the reading of the journal is

[00:54:04] waived the chair the chair recognizes the clerk will report any communication from the house the chair recognizes the senator from eastern fairfax oh good afternoon madame president good afternoon madame president moved to wave reading of the communication from the house of

[00:54:44] delegates the question is shall the reading of the communication be waived all in favor of waiving the reading from the of the communication from the house of delegates will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote. The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 33 knows 5. Ayes 33 knows 5. The reading of the communication is waived. The clerk will report any communications from the governor.

[00:55:18] I do not have any, Madam President. We are now ready to welcome our new senator. Elizabeth B. bennett parker took and subscribed the oath prescribed by law on february 19th 2026 at 12 15 p.m the oath and certificate of election have been referred to the committee on privileges and elections the senator from portsmouth thank you madam president madam president as a senior most

[00:55:56] member of this body in both age and seniority, it gives me a great deal of pleasure to be able to welcome our newest member of the body. Senator-elect Elizabeth Bennet Parker comes to the upper chamber after years of service as an effective policymaker. She is a hard-working, dedicated legislator who delves into complex policy issues and brings people together. As a fifth member of the House of Delegates to give birth while in office, she is a champion for children and families, advancing causes like accessibility for child care and

[00:56:36] affordable housing. She has also passed bills to better protect survivors of domestic violence and stalking and strengthen rights protections for individuals with disabilities. In her first term, she passed more bills than any other Democratic freshman and since then has consistently delivered meaningful legislation for her community. Prior to joining the House of Delegates, She served as vice mayor of Alexandria, helping to lead the city through complex challenges like housing and transportation.

[00:57:09] She brought together residents, small business owners, labor leaders, and advocates at the table and built coalitions that advance thoughtful and lasting reforms. Before serving in elective office, she founded a small business and then co-led a non-profit working with women returning from the criminal justice system.

[00:57:29] She's carried her passion from criminal justice reform and food security into the legislature. Beyond her professional achievements, she brings compassion, commitment, and community-minded leadership to this upper chamber.

[00:57:46] Born in Alexandria to two naval officers, she remains deeply rooted in the community she now represents. After graduating Phi Beta Kappa from Cornell University, serving as a Fulbright Fellow in Singapore and earning a master's from the University of London, she returned to Alexandra.

[00:58:06] She lives with her husband, Stephen, their rescue dog, Kat, and their daughter, who brings joy to their lives to keep them on their toes. I ask my colleagues to join me in welcoming Senator-elect Elizabeth Bennet Parker to the Senate of Virginia.

[00:58:25] We've now arrived in the time of our morning hour, when we have the honor of welcoming

[00:59:04] our distinguished guests who are joining us here in the gallery today. I give my daily reminder about our procedure. Our Senator will rise and welcome their guest. I will then offer the welcome of the Senate. I ask that we all hold our applause until I've had the opportunity to provide the Senate's welcome. The chair recognizes the Senator from Western Henrico. Thank you Madam President.

[00:59:30] Madam President, I rise for an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Thank you Madam President. Madam President, today giving us the invocation was Imam Kamran Shaikh. If he would please rise. Kamran Shaikh is a student of knowledge who, for over the last 10 years, has served members of the West End Islamic Senator, conducting classes for adults and young families.

[00:59:52] He gives Friday sermons at various mosques across the Richmond area and is actively engaged with the interfaith community. He's also a proud owner of the business, the T-shirt studio in RVA in Kerrytown. If you know, you know. for the last last 13 years and most importantly i would just say you know you get in this game and you've been and when you're around for a while you kind of know who's real and who's not you know who does the community work and you know who doesn't uh and he's always there he's always doing stuff in our community he's always making our community a better place and so i'm really glad he could come here today and share some wisdom with us and so i hope we give him a warm senate

[01:00:26] welcome thank you senator for that introduction and please remain standing imam we are delighted to welcome you thank you so much for providing the prayer and blessings this morning to our senate chamber thank you for all the work that you do throughout the community we are indebted to public servants such as yourself senators i ask that we give the warm welcome of the senate to imam kamran sheikh from the west end islamic center the chair recognizes the

[01:01:03] senator from hanover thank you madam president madam president i rise for the purposes of an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Madam President, today we are joined by a group of second grade students from St. Bridget's here in Richmond. Madam President, we have a group of students including among them is Henry Reynolds and they are joined by their teachers Teresa, Natalie, and Lauren and their assistant principal Bridget Nielsen. Madam President, they've had the opportunity to see something that does not usually occur on the floor of this

[01:01:43] body with the swearing in of our new member and so that is a great thing for them to be able to see we hope they have a great time at the Capitol and look forward to them returning maybe in some of the seats down here one day if you could offer them the warm welcome to the the Senate on a rainy and historic day thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to our second graders you have been sitting so patiently and I have been delighted to be waving to you this morning. Thank you for your patience and this is a truly historic day. You've witnessed the swearing-in of our brand-new senator and thank you for

[01:02:22] bringing your teachers and your principal with you. We hope you have a wonderful visit while you're here. And senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to the second grade class of St. Bridget's School here in the Richmond area. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Prince William.

[01:02:53] Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. In the gallery are cadets and officers from my alma mater, the Virginia Military Institute in Lexington, Virginia. I ask that you please stand. VMI is the oldest state-supported military college in the country, founded in 1839. These cadets are part of a group of upperclassmen in Richmond today meeting with their legislators to thank them for their support of higher education and the Institute this evening these cadets will join alumni faculty and staff from

[01:03:29] Virginia Military Institute at the Library of Virginia for the Institute's legislative reception from 6:00 to 8:00 p.m. tonight please come by and visit with the cadets at this event I ask that you give them a warm Senate welcome Thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to the cadets of VMI. We're so delighted that you are here today You've been visiting the the Capitol a few times this session and we're always happy to see you I hope you've been having wonderful conversations as you visit our legislators offices and certainly looking forward to the reception that you will be hosting this evening

[01:04:09] Senators I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to the VMI cadets officers the chair recognizes a senior senator from Loudoun good morning madam president madam president I writes for the purposes of two introductions the senator has the floor thank you madam president madam president here in the audience today is the better half of my teammate I can't see her but I understand

[01:04:47] she's up there this is councilwoman Jennifer Rouse who represents the 10th district of Virginia Beach Jennifer is a professor of sociology at Tidewater Community College and is currently working toward her PhD in public Policy at ODU. She is joined by their 14-month-old daughter Olivia and her mother Margie Valentine, Margie Valentine. And I keep telling my seatmate that she, I don't know her personally actually, but I hear the most wonderful things about her all the time. And so I keep telling him that

[01:05:27] there may be a primary in the mix coming down. The Rouses will be celebrating their fifth wedding anniversary tomorrow madam president and i ask that you please give um jennifer and her

family the warm welcome of the senate thank you for that introduction senator and welcome to council councilwoman jennifer rouse welcome to olivia and welcome to mrs valentine thank you all for joining us and all of the support that you provide to our senator from virginia beach we really appreciate

[01:06:01] all that you do and delighted to see you here and especially wishing you a very very happy fifth anniversary senators i ask that we give the warm welcome of the senate to the family of our junior senator from virginia beach senior senator from loudon thank you madam president madam president um i have another i raise for the purposes of another introduction senator has the floor thank you madam president madam president ladies and gentlemen of the senate i rise today

[01:06:39] to recognize an outstanding group of young leaders visiting us from northern virginia as part of the electric electric cooperative youth tour program if they are here if they don't mind rising i also can't see them i guess everyone come stand behind me perfect um uh their names are hadley diamond isabel amante and sajid ju guru and i did get lessons before i came down here um these students represent northern virginia electric cooperative and were selected for their leadership academic achievement and commitment to their communities to be here today as part of the youth tour these students will join fellow student leaders residing in

[01:07:17] electric cooperative territory from across the country for a visit to Washington DC this summer where they will meet with members of Congress learn about our nation's history and gain a deeper understanding of public service and civic leadership and while they will soon visit our nation's capital today they get to witness where so much of that spirit began here in Virginia seeing up close how ideas are debated, laws are shaped, and public service comes to life in the Commonwealth.

[01:07:42] Please join me, Madam President, in welcoming these exceptional students to the Senate today. Thank you, Senator, for that introduction and welcome to our representatives from the Northern Virginia Electric Cooperative Youth Tour Program. We're so delighted that you are stopping by here in Richmond. I'm sure you're learning quite a bit and contributing quite a bit as well. Thank you so much for being a part of this unique program. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome

[01:08:10] of the Senate to the Northern Virginia Electric Cooperative U-Tour program. The chair recognizes the Senator from Prince Edward. Thank you, Madam President. I rise to request a leave of absence from my seatmate who's away on pressing personal business. The journal will so reflect. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the Senator from King George. Thank you madam president Ross for the purposes of an introduction senator has

[01:08:50] the floor madam president members in the gallery today we have to demand cure an honor lesson and I just point out to the body that to these brother Tom served down in the lower chamber many years ago and she's spent a lot of time over here at the Capitol but this is orange first visit to the Virginia State Capitol um they are both friends and constituents from back at home and King George very involved in their community and serving the community and trying to trying to make it better and I would ask that you all give them the warm welcome of the

[01:09:27] Senate thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to Tutti and to Arne thank you so much for joining us today we know you have an exceptional representative in the figure of our senator from King George and we are delighted to have you visit the Capitol and join us in the gallery senators I I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to Tutti Moncour and Arne Eliasson.

[01:10:05] The chair recognizes the senator from Norfolk. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today we are honored to welcome a distinguished group of nonprofit leaders and community advocates to the Senate of Virginia for nonprofits at the Capitol Day, and I would ask them all to stand.

[01:10:31] These organizations serve the residents of Norfolk and the Greater Hampton Roads region every single day, meeting critical needs, strengthening families, and filling gaps where services are most needed. Nonprofits are often the first to respond and the last to leave.

[01:10:50] They provide food security, housing assistance, workforce development, youth mentorship, health care access violence prevention and countless other essential services that help our communities thrive their work is not only compassionate it is strategic impactful and vital to the well-being of the commonwealth today's visit gives these leaders the opportunity to engage directly with their legislators network and hear updates on the work of the general assembly their voices help inform the policies we shape in this chamber. Madam President, I would like to

[01:11:30] take a moment and recognize each organization that is present here today. Our Children, Our Village, 4Kids, Inc., Access Virginia, the Elizabeth River Trail Foundation, Big Homies, Inc., Teens with a Purpose, Vision Driven 757, and inclusively inclusive which was started by a student at virginia commonwealth university please join me in welcoming and thanking these dedicated non-profit leaders for the critical work they do on behalf of our communities thank you senator for that introduction and

[01:12:08] just listening to the the resume of names and organizations that are represented we know the kind of impact that you are having all throughout our communities in so many different and diverse ways thank you for your leadership thank you for all that you do to support so many who count on you to provide this outreach and engagement and support senators i ask that we give the very warm

[01:12:34] welcome of the senate to our representatives from a variety of norfolk non-profits the chair recognizes the senator from western fairfax thank you madam president i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor madam president today in the gallery we have blythe jones blythe joined my office as an intern in the fall and she assisted us with all sorts of fun tasks

[01:13:10] but mostly with research on legislative and policy issues that we were working on Blythe is a fourth year student at UCLA who got involved in Virginia politics as part of a UCLA program where she started an internship with the Fairfax County Board of Supervisors.

[01:13:34] After that she joined us and today she flew all the way here from Los Angeles to watch us do our work to learn about uh the legislative process in virginia and to watch the bills that she has helped us uh with this past fall um pass hopefully uh as as we uh go through this process um i hope you'll join me in welcoming blithe to the senate and she'll be going back home to

[01:14:10] California soon and she's looking to maybe start working in the California Senate so madam chair we had to show her what the right way to govern is here before we sent her back home so please welcome Blythe thank you senator for that introduction and I fully agree with you that the Senate of Virginia far outshines the Senate of California we hope you'll find your way back to Virginia at some point soon. But thank you for the support that you provided to our senator doing research in her office and wishing you the very best of

[01:14:46] success as you move forward in your personal and professional career. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to Blythe Jones. The chair recognizes the senator from Washington. Thank you Madam President. I rise for two introductions. The senator has the floor. Madam President, in the gallery, Eddie Thomas, if he'll stand, joins us all the way from my native county of Lee. Eddie faithfully served at what was once the Lee Regional Medical Center and is today

[01:15:25] the Lee County Community Hospital since 1975. It was my honor to sponsor Senate resolution number 10 that passed earlier this session commending Eddie for 50 years of service to his community. Throughout those five decades Eddie remained dedicated daily to through mergers, challenges, and even the hospital's closure. He safeguarded that facility during that difficult chapter and played a vital role in its reopening in 2021. So please join me in celebrating Eddie's remarkable dedication by welcoming him and his wife Kathy to

[01:16:01] our Senate, to his Senate. Thank you Senator for that introduction and welcome to to Eddie and to Kathy. Thank you so much for joining us and as we just heard from our Senator, Mr. Thomas, your years, decades of service to our Commonwealth and most especially to making sure that we are providing the critical health care services to our rural areas is so deeply valued. Thank you for all that you have done and continue to do. Senators, I ask that

[01:16:33] we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to Eddie and Kathy Thomas, the Senator from Washington. thank you madam president i would also like to recognize representatives of the pentagon memorial fund joining us today if they would stand nearly 25 years ago 184 lives were lost when american airlines flight 77 struck the pentagon right here on virginia soil while many in this chamber remember exactly where they were on that morning for a new generation september 11th is just a

[01:17:12] chapter in a history book rather than a live memory and as we approach the 25th remembrance the fund is here to ensure our nation's honors the solemn promise to never forget i ask that we also give them a warm welcome of their senate thank you senator for that introduction and thank you to our representatives from the pentagon memorial fund we are indebted to the work that you do to make sure that we continue to honor and recognize our beloved family members and community members who lost their lives on that tragic day thank you for

[01:17:48] the education uh and the information that you continue to share to our next generation senators i ask that we give the very warm welcome of the senate to our representatives from the pentagon memorial fund the chair recognizes the senior senator from virginia beach thank you madam president i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor madam president i rise today to

[01:18:25] introduce a very special group of visitors to our capital joining us in the gallery today we have students from Regent University's Undergraduate School of Government and Accounting. They also represent the leadership of Regent University's chapter of American-Israeli Political Affairs Committee and Turning Point USA.

[01:18:43] They are here as part of their educational journey to witness the legislative process firsthand. These students represent the bright future of our Commonwealth. It's an honor to welcome them to Richmond. They're here to learn about how state government works and I hope their visit will be both informative and inspiring madam president on behalf of myself the junior senator from Virginia Beach and the senator from Chesapeake I ask that we offer the warm welcome of the Senate as they explore the

heart of Virginia's government and gain invaluable insight into the democratic process thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to the representatives from

[01:19:22] Regents University thank you for the work that you are doing and I know you're engaged in so many conversations throughout the day. Hopefully these conversations will continue as you connect with our lawmakers and make sure that you share the issues and the priorities that you are championing.

[01:19:40] Senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to the students and representatives of Regent University. The chair recognizes the senator from Northern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I have a number of introduction the senator has the floor thank you madam president I'm gonna start I have a group of interns who are here with us today and in the gallery we

[01:20:16] have Juliet Morrow who has been with me since she was a high school student and she's now a junior at the University of Virginia she studies foreign affairs and Middle Eastern studies and really an impressive young woman she is actually fluent in both English and in Turkish and has been just really a huge asset to my team. Next I have Morgan Noop. She is a senior at the University of Richmond studying history and political science. She's excited to pursue a career in public policy upon graduation this May. So for anyone who's looking for a new

[01:20:54] staffer, Morgan is here. She is the chair of her Senate of the West Hampton College Government Association and she also works for the administration office. Next we have Danielle Issa and she's a junior. She is at also at the University of Richmond and also studies political science and history. She's excited to continue her studies and pursue a career in public policy and government.

[01:21:22] She has another year of school so we can talk to her again next year. She currently works as a tour guide for the admissions office and she's the president of the weightlifting club. Very impressive. And she joined me in my office upon Senator Eben's exit to the General Assembly. So I ask you to give these these people a warm welcome and then I got a few more. Thank you Senator for that introduction and welcome to Danielle, Juliet and Morgan. Thank you for all the support that you've been providing to our senators, two senators

[01:22:01] it sounds like, to their offices. We are delighted that you've been able to work within our state government and certainly hope that you are learning a lot, but we know that you have been contributing so much as well. Senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to Danielle, Juliet, and to Morgan. Senator from Northern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. Today I have

[01:22:35] Michael Arco with his children Nicholas, Sienna, and Allegra. Michael and his kids lost Claudia Arco who all of us here in Fairfax County knew for many years. She was the representative from Fairfax County government who helped us understand what the issues were for Fairfax County and she passed away last April we're just terribly sorry for their loss and but you know I just wanted to talk about a little bit about about Michael's wife because she was an

[01:23:13] amazing woman she always had a smile always remembered the humanity in each person that she interacted with she was a devoted wife and mom she was the president of her PTA she organized sports teams and served as team mom she She championed all of her kids, Nicholas, Sienna and Allegra, and everything that they did.

[01:23:39] It's a real loss to all of us. I wish that we could give the warm welcome and condolences to the Arco family today, and I thank you for that. Thank you, Senator, and welcome to the family of Claudia

Huntman-Arco.

[01:23:56] Thank you for joining us today. We know this is a difficult time, but as the senator shared, Claudia's impact on so many throughout the community has been meaningful and very, very important, and we express our condolences for the loss of your family, but we're happy that we are here to honor the memory and the lifetime of service of Claudia Arco.

[01:24:23] I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the family of Claudia Arco.

[01:24:40] And Madam President, I have one. Senator has the floor. I'm going to combine my last two into one introduction because they're here for the same purpose. We have Timothy Walker with the Humanization Project, and we have a number of loved ones and friends of my dear friend, Sincere Allah, here in the gallery with us.

[01:25:03] These individuals who are here have worked on criminal justice reform and prison reform and social justice issues They are here to recognize the work that sincere Provided to all of us in the friendship. I'll be speaking after session, but I ask that you give them the very warm and Gentle welcome of the Senate. Thank you senator And if our guests will stand Timothy Walker from the Humanization Project, and other representatives from the Humanization Project, and the family and friends of

[01:25:41] Sincere Allah, who we tragically lost a few days ago. We know that this is a difficult time for so many in the communities. Your presence here represents many, many more who are mourning the loss of our dear friend, beloved brother, someone who provided so much and gave so much to many many in our communities.

[01:26:07] Our thoughts and prayers are with everyone who is mourning this loss. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to all those who loved and cherish the memory of sincere Allah.

[01:26:22] Is there any other business to come before the morning hour?

[01:26:41] The clerk will call the calendar. Senate Calendar for Thursday, February 19, 2026. Unfinished Business Senate. Senate Bill 347 has passed the House with a substitute.

[01:26:59] The Senator from Western Henrico. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I'm going to move that we concur with the House substitute in speaking to that motion. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, members of the body, this is essentially the same bill that we sent over to the house in in framework ban the bans and create voluntary standards around solar siting what this substitute does is it represents a kind of updated compromise among a bunch of the different stakeholder groups not all of them but a bunch of them so it has some technical fixes

[01:27:34] on wetland protections that will be more protective of the chesapeake bay protection act in in the chesapeake bay wetlands it establishes a grandfathering clause and ensures existing investments are protected and it clarifies the timeline for applicability of the new standards which i once again want to emphasize are voluntary and are based on best practices so i move that we concur with the house substitute with the recommendation that the senate concur with the house substitute the question is shall the house substitute be agreed to all in favor of

[01:28:13] that motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the role eyes 21 nose 18

eyes 21 nose 18 the senate concurs with the house substitute we are awaiting house action on pages on the bills on pages 2 through 4 on page 4 uncontested

[01:28:50] calendar house bills on third reading the senator from Eastern Fairfax madam president I move that all the house bills on third reading on the uncontested calendar pages 4 through 5 Senate House bill 799 through 1180 they advance their final passage in a block after the adoption amendments thereto that any senator desire move bill from the block should do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill the question is shall house bills on the uncontested calendar third reading pages 4 through 5 house bill 799 through house bill 1180 be placed upon

[01:29:27] their final passage in the block after the adoption of any amendments thereto with the understanding that any senator desiring a bill to be removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill all in favor of that motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The bills are now before us in the block. The clerk will read the number of the bills. House Bill 799 reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations. House Bill 800 reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations. House Bill 1076 reported from the

[01:30:06] Committee on Finance and Appropriations. House Bill 1180 reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations. The question is, shall the House bills in the block pass. All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye.

[01:30:22] Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, no zero.

[01:30:40] Ayes 39, no zero. The bills in the block pass. Regular calendar, House bills on third reading. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[01:31:04] Sorry, I didn't know we were ringing them out. Madam President, I move that we suspend the rules and grade the privileges of the floor to the Senate Finance Committee staff so they can support us while we debate this budget bill.

[01:31:25] The question is, shall the rules be suspended and the privileges of the floor be granted to the committee from Senate Finance and Appropriations? All in favor of the motion will record their votes, aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote?

[01:31:40] Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, noes 0. Ayes 39, noes 0. The privileges of the floor are granted.

[01:32:05] Regular calendar House bills on third reading.

[01:32:25] House Bill 29, a budget bill amends and reenacts Chapter 725 of the Acts of Assembly of 2025, which appropriates the public revenues for two years ending respectively on June 30th, 2025 and June 30th, 2026.

[01:32:50] Reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations with Senate amendments is substituted for House amendments. The Senator from Portsmouth.

[01:33:12] Does Senate Finance and Appropriations be agreed to in speaking to that? The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President the amendment package for HB 29 is the same as what we did for SB 29 except there are technical changes to tax conformity changes to redistricting that includes technical changes and the addition of language directed agencies to rejoin the regional

greenhouse initiative reggie a total of four total of 10 amendments and Madam President I move that the committee members be agreed to the senator from Hanover thank you Madam President Madam President could

[01:33:49] amendment number two titled 77 1s amendment number four titled 365 1s amendment number eight four dash five point zero four number one s amendment number nine four dash fourteen number one s and an amendment number ten four dash fourteen number two s come out of the block without objection those

[01:34:19] amendments are out of the block. The question is, Senator from Rockingham. Madam President, I would ask if the center from Portsmouth or I will wait.

[01:34:39] Thank you. The question is, shall the Senate amendments be agreed to all in a block all except for amendment number 277 number 1s amendment 4365 number 1s amendment 8 4-5.04

[01:35:08] number 1s amendment 9 4-14 number 1s amendment 10 4-14 number 2 all in favor of that motion will say aye. Those opposed no. The ayes have it. The amendments are agreed to.

[01:35:28] Amendment 77 number one. Senator from Portsmouth. Thank you Madam President. Madam President I move that the committee amendment be agreed to. Would

[01:36:03] the senator speak to the amendment? Madam President speaking to the amendment. Senator has the floor. Ladies and gentlemen Senate you might recall that I think was about two years ago about four years ago we had a joint campaign finance study between the House and the Senate, and one of the recommendations that came out of that, it was a bipartisan study, I want to remind everybody, one of the recommendations that came out of that was that we audit campaign finance reports, a certain percentage of them

[01:36:39] after every election. We adopted that legislation, I want to say two years ago, and I believe this is the first year that that's coming into effect. I believe the law requires 10% of all campaigns each cycle to be audited by random draw. The Board of Elections, I think, did its draw around the first week of January. They sent all of us notices. You should have gotten a notice about it. I believe what this amendment does is delays the reporting on the results of those

[01:37:10] audits by five months. I assume, given the text, it delays it six months from July 1 to December 31. I think that's what the text of this amendment does. So that's all I know.

[01:37:30] Thank you. The question is, shall Amendment 2, 77, number 1S, be agreed to? All in favor of that motion will say aye. Those opposed, no.

[01:37:47] The ayes have it. The amendment is agreed to. Number 4, 365, 1. The senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[01:38:06] Thank you, Madam President. I move amendment 365 1S. I don't know what number it is. I don't have that in front of me. Number four. I move amendment number four and speak to that motion. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Ladies and gentlemen, Senate, this has to do with Reggie. You all might, I mean, obviously everybody knows that we passed a law, I think it was in 2021, requiring the Air Board to have us join Reggie.

[01:38:31] The new governor came in a couple years ago, or Governor Youngkin came in and decided that he had the authority to withdraw us from Reggie. There was a disagreement about that. There was a

lawsuit filed. The court found that the governor was wrong to withdraw us from RGGI and that the law required us to stay in RGGI.

[01:38:47] The senator from Hampton has a bill this year to make it, I guess, especially clear that we're supposed to be in RGGI, even though we've already made that clear in law. And the case is on appeal, I believe, right now. And this amendment would accelerate that. It would have us rejoin RGGI now instead of waiting for that law to become effective July 1.

[01:39:05] I think it would probably help remove any uncertainty in litigation and get this process restarted so the Virginians could start enjoying the benefits of RGGI again sooner rather than later. Just note that under RGGI, 50% of funds raised have to go to low-income energy efficiency projects. And I think in a time of affordability, giving people the funds and the ability to reduce their energy bills is an excellent solution. Energy efficiency has been shown to be the most efficient way to generate energy savings it's more efficient than building new generation or infrastructure um and i would also just note and i'm sure that it um in some places where power

[01:39:42] bills are really um high in some parts of the state they would really appreciate the help but also know 45 of the money goes to virginia community flood preparedness fund and that has funded projects all over the state especially in some of our hardest hit areas in the mountains which have been getting hit by massive increases in rainfall generated by climate change between 2021 23 this generated 827 million dollars for both of those two for both the flood fund and low income energy and uh this amendment just makes it clear that we gotta rejoin and rejoin now instead

[01:40:16] of waiting around another five months i hope we could vote for it senator from hanover thank you madam president madam president speaking to the motion senator has the floor thank you madam president madam president we've talked about this topic a lot topic of reggie and madam president it It is very clear that Virginians have paid almost 900 million dollars as a tax on their power bill.

[01:40:44] Make no mistake, if you got a power bill, you paid a tax for joining this program. That program stopped and you're not paying that tax right now. But Madam President, speaking to the Virginians that are looking at their power bills today and seeing how high they are, if this passes, your bills will be higher.

[01:41:09] It will cost you more money. This is a tax on your power bill to say, "Oh, we're going to do something else positive, but we're going to tax you to do it." That is not affordability. That is taking money out of your pocket.

[01:41:24] Madam President, yesterday we heard the Governor's Secretary of Finance saying revenues were almost $600 million more this year than we had budgeted for. If these programs, if you want to fund these programs, there's $600 million there that the governor's secretary said is president.

[01:41:47] We should not be taxing Virginians to do this. Telling people you're going to tax them to give you something back is a shell game. It is not affordability.

[01:42:04] The question is, shall amendment number 4365 number 1S be agreed to? in favor of that motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the amen seeing at least eight hands this will be a recorded vote all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change

[01:42:39] their vote. The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 21, noes 18. Ayes 21, noes 18. Amendment number 4 is agreed to. Amendment number 8, 4-5.041. The senator from Charlottesville. Madam President, I move that the amendment passed and I'd like to speak to that. The senator has the floor. Madam President, ladies and gentlemen, this amendment simply ensures that people on Medicaid can have

[01:43:14] Benefit the benefit of services for for abortion care went from when the fetal abnormality is present again I move that pass the question is show amendment 8 4 - 5.04 number one be agreed to all in favor of that motion We'll say aye those opposed. No The eyes have it the amendment is agreed to amendment number 9 4 - 14 point 1 the senator from Portsmouth

[01:43:53] Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the committee members of the Senate of Finance and Appropriations be agreed to and speaking to that amendment. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. These are the redistricting changes and what they include is the Department of Elections requested administrative language related to running the actual election. Technical physics fixes to minuscule misaligned census blocks in Lynchburg and Pulaski County. Additionally, changes to the second and the third districts. And with that, madam president i renew my motion to have the committee amendments agreed to the senator from

[01:44:26] rockingham madam president i'd ask if the senator from portsmouth would yield for a couple of questions will the senator from portsmouth yield yes ma'am madam president i'm here senator from rockingham madam president i would ask i i heard in the description of this amendment and in committee I guess a couple of days ago that the changes that were made with respect to the maps were technical changes which I typically understand to

[01:45:02] be resolving split precincts and things like that is that the nature of the changes or are there more extensive changes than that that are reflected in this amendment. Senator from Portsmouth. Madam President, Senator, that's the understanding that I have and the only other information that I have is that all references in the fourth enactment to boundary of the counties and cities and the precincts shall be interpreted or to be referred to as those existing as of April 1st, 2021. Madam President, further question. Senator from Rockingham.

[01:45:40] Madam President, I read last night or actually this morning in the Times Dispatch that they were reporting that the changes actually shifted 4,000 more Democratic voters into the second congressional district and 6,000 Republican voters out of the second district into the third congressional district. I would ask if that report from

[01:46:16] the Times Dispatch is accurate or whether that is the nature of the technical changes that are made. Madam President, I would say to the Senator from Rockingham that I'm not sure that that's altogether accurate. I do know that there were some changes made to the second and the third, but I was told it was because of Little Rivers and contributaries or whatever the case may be. But as far as the actual numbers, I can't verify that for you. Madam President, Senator from Rockingham. Madam President, that article

[01:46:52] actually quoted Larry Sabato, you know, and his quote was, "I thought they'd do Loria more of a favor than was reflected in the first set of maps."

[01:47:08] And their report indicates that these changes changed the second congressional district where I understand Ms. Lauria may be a Democratic candidate, changed it from a district where Governor

Spanberger won by 8 percent, which I guess Mr. Sabato considered to be too close, to a district where she would have won by 12.6 percent.

[01:47:41] You know whether, I would ask the Senator from Portsmouth whether she knows whether that's accurate. Senator from Portsmouth. Madam President, I would say to the Senator from Rockingham that I think that's a bit speculative, but I can tell you Larry Sabato's been doing this a lot longer than I have and perhaps he'd be the person to ask that question.

[01:48:00] Madam President, further question. Senator from Rockingham, will the Senator yield for another question? Yes, Madam President, I yield. I would ask Madam President whether it is true that there is a version of the maps that were circulated to members of Congress and to members of the General Assembly that actually had names written in for each of the congressional districts.

[01:48:26] Senator from Portsmouth. Madam President, I would say to the Senator from Rockingham, I was told the same thing, but I never saw it. Madam President, further question. Will the Senator yield for another question? Madam President, I yield for a further question. Senator from Rockingham.

[01:48:41] Madam President, I actually read that in the Virginia Scope, and they said that the maps were drawn by Virginia House Democrats and the National Redistricting Democratic Committee.

[01:48:59] I would ask whether that's accurate. Senator from Portsmouth. Madam President, I would say to the Senator from Rockingham, I had my own map drawer, so I don't know who the other person was. Further question, Madam President. will the senator yield for another question madam president i don't mind doing this all evening senator from rockingham i won't do i won't uh hold you all evening but i would ask uh this map is coming over from the house and my question is if the scope is right did they not show senate democrats those maps with the names written in senator from portsmouth madam president i would

[01:49:39] respond to the senator from Rockingham I never saw a map with anybody's name on I did see a map with some dots on it but they did not have names on it so I don't know who those dots represented madam president senator from Rockingham madam president further question will the senator yield yes ma'am madam president I yield senator from Rockingham madam president in light of the fact that we are being asked to vote in the affirmative to accept the House Amendments, which will become all of our amendments to this map.

[01:50:13] If there are maps out there that have names on them, don't you think it would be fair to tell all of the voters in Virginia who's been selected to represent them in Congress before they go to the polls to vote?

[01:50:31] Senator from Portsmouth. Madam President, I would say to the Senator from Rockingham, the only person I know that's been selected has been Elaine Laurier from Virginia Beach. Senator from Rockingham. Madam President, speaking to the amendment. The Senator has the floor.

[01:50:48] Madam President, I'm not quite sure about that last answer, but so Madam President, speaking to the amendment, I gather from the comments of the Senator from Portsmouth that there is at least one name that has been selected as somebody who is designated to serve in Congress under these maps and I guess that's the announced candidate from Virginia Beach in the second congressional district the Democrat

[01:51:23] running these are substantial changes this is political gerrymandering not just plain vanilla political gerrymandering it is on steroids we have commentators in Virginia who are commenting that, "Gosh, we didn't give enough Democratic votes to certain congressional candidates and certain districts." So what happened? The map drawers, apparently, according to the

[01:51:59] responses to these questions and the Virginia scope, the map drawers down the hall and maybe in Washington went back to the drawing board and further fixed the fix with respect to the second congressional district.

[01:52:16] What I find even more disturbing and, you know, I understand gerrymandering and that's what happens in gerrymandering is, you know, they continue to jigger the districts until they get them right.

[01:52:32] And I guess the map drawers figure this is getting them right. But what I find especially troubling is that reporters reported actually seeing these maps with names written in for each of the districts.

[01:52:50] These are districts that are drawn for specific people, at least according to published reports over the past couple of days. It appears to me that my friends, maybe down the hall, maybe not in here, but friends in and allies in Washington have handpicked ten people to represent Virginians in Congress.

[01:53:18] And they told members of the General Assembly, apparently not members in here, but they told members of the General Assembly who those people are. But they're not telling Virginia voters who has been handpicked to represent them.

[01:53:39] We heard during the course of the debate earlier in session that we're going to be real transparent. When we send this to the voters in April, we're going to show them a copy of the map before they go to the polls and vote.

[01:53:55] And yes, we do have a copy of the map, and I guess Virginia voters should be grateful for that. But last I checked, voters are supposed to be selecting the people who represent them, not the other way around.

[01:54:10] And this is a poster case for elected officials selecting the people they want to represent the voters. That's not the way it's supposed to work.

[01:54:26] I think the voters of Virginia deserve more and deserve better. And I would certainly hope that we would consider voting no on this map. - The Senator from Arlington.

[01:54:47] - To speak in favor of the amendment. - The Senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. I just wanna set the record straight. No candidates have been pre-selected. We are going to have primaries. Voters are gonna select the candidates in these new districts.

[01:55:04] There's nothing in this amendment that says anything about candidates. So I don't know what newspapers are reporting or what news outlets are reporting. There are lots of rumors, let's just deal with what's in front of us and that that has madam chair just presented the madam chair of Senate Finance and Appropriations she explained which precincts were being moved that's what's before us nothing more I hope that the body does adopt this amendment madam president with the center from Arlington yield for a question will the senator yield yes senator from

[01:55:43] Rockingham madam president I would ask the center from Arlington whether the map drawers showed her the maps with the names written in that were shown to people down the hall and the

members of the media or whether they kept her in the dark as well. Senator from Arlington. I did not see any maps with names on it. I think my friend. Thank you. The question is shall amendment 9 4-14 number 1s be

[01:56:22] agreed to all in favor of that motion will say aye those opposed no the chair is not certain this will be a recorded vote all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll ayes 21 noes 18 ayes 21 noes 18 the amendment is agreed to

[01:56:58] to. Amendment number 10, 4-14.2. The senior senator from Prince William. Thank you, Madam President. Move that the amendment be agreed to and speaking to the motion. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. So this is the exact same amendment that was previously approved in the Senate version of the budget. This language and amendment simply includes technical amendments requested by tax in order to get this right. As you see the revenue and the adjustments are the exact same as it passed through the Senate. So I'd ask for

[01:57:27] its adoption the question is shall senate shall the amendment number 10 4-14 number two be agreed to all in favor of that motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the amendment is agreed

[01:57:49] to senator from portsmouth thank you madam president i don't know how much i can say that no one has really been named for any of these seats that i think has already been stated that that this is going to be a primary.

[01:58:21] And the voters will decide who will represent them. So with that, Madam President, I move that bill pass in its entirety. The question is, shall HB 29 pass? All in favor of that motion will record their votes, aye.

[01:58:39] Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. -Ayes 21, noes 18.

[01:58:54] -Ayes 21, noes 18. House Bill 29 passes.

[01:59:05] The Senate will be at ease.

[02:06:06] -Aye's Bill 161, a bill relating to tax exemptions Confederacy organizations, reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations. -Senior Senator from Prince William.

[02:06:22] -Thank you, Madam President. I move the bill pass and speak into the motion. -The Senator has the floor. -Thank you, Madam President. This is a bill that this chamber is familiar with. It eliminates the recordation tax exemption for any deed conveying real estate or lease on real estate to the Virginia Division of United Daughters.

[02:06:37] The Confederacy eliminates the tax exemption designations for real property owned by several Confederate-related organizations across the Virginia, Madam President. This is a bill that went through the chamber also in 2025 and moved its passage. - The question is, shall House Bill 167 be agreed to?

[02:06:56] All in favor of that motion will record their votes, aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll.

[02:07:12] Ayes 21, noes 17. Ayes 21, noes 17. House Bill 167 passes. House Bill 341, a bill relating to plastic bag tax distribution to towns. Reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations.

[02:07:29] The senior senator from Prince William. Thank you, Madam President. Move the bill pass and speak into the motion. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. This is also identical to a bill we saw last year. It requires any county in which the disposable bag tax is imposed to distribute a share of that bag tax revenue to any town that's situated in such county.

[02:07:49] The current counties that have this implemented are Albemarle, Arlington, Fairfax, Loudoun, so to apply to those towns within and move its passage. The question is, shall House Bill 341 pass? All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye.

[02:08:07] Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted. Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 22, noes 16. Ayes 22, noes 16.

[02:08:23] House Bill 341 passes. House Bill 550, a bill relating to admissions tax in counties, retail sales and use tax dedicated to promotion of tourism reported from the committee on finance and appropriations the senior senator from Prince William thank you madam president move the bill passed and speaking to the motion the senator has the floor thank you madam president this is the bill that's identical to Senate bill 400 that from the senator from York dealing with imposition of sales sales and use tax of 1% dedicated to the promotion of tourism of course

[02:09:00] there's only one tourism sales tax historic district in the historic triangle and would only apply to James City County in York County and move the bill's passage the question is shall House Bill 550 pass all in favor of that motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll I was 24 nose 14 eyes 24 nose 14 house bill 550

[02:09:40] passes memorial resolutions the senator from Eastern Fairfax madam president I move that whoops I move the memorial resolutions on pages 6 through 8 HJR 117 SJR 113 be considered block in the usual manner waving the reading for the resolutions there over the understanding that any senator desiring a resolution removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the resolution.

[02:10:15] The question is, shall the memorial resolutions on pages six through eight, H.J.R. 117 through S.J.R. 113 be considered in the block in the usual manner, waiving the reading of the resolutions thereof with the understanding that any senator desiring a resolution be removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the title of the resolution. All in favor of that motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The resolutions are before us in the block. The clerk will read the titles of the memorial

[02:10:53] resolutions. House Joint Resolutions 117, celebrating the life of Russell Elliott Wiley. House Joint Resolution 118, celebrating the life of Lloyd G. Edwards, Jr. House Joint Resolution 120, celebrating the life of Lucille Mary Brown. House Joint Resolution 128, celebrating the life of Claudia Hateman Arco. House Joint Resolution 132, celebrating the life of Margaret

[02:11:32] Peters Stalmaker. House Senate Joint Resolution 101, celebrating the life of Gladys Mae West. Senate Joint Resolution 102, celebrating the life of Claudia Hantman Arco.

[02:11:50] Senate Joint Resolution 105, celebrating the life of Margaret Peter Stahlmaker. Senate Joint Resolution 108, celebrating the life of Marvin Sherlock Holmes Sr. Senate Joint Resolution 109, celebrating the life of Virginia Moselle Jefferson Tyler.

[02:12:13] Senate Joint Resolution 110, celebrating the life of Lucille Murray Brown. Senate Joint Resolution 113, celebrating the life of Sincere B. Alla.

[02:12:32] The resolutions will be agreed to in the usual manner. All those in favor of agreeing to the memorial resolutions, please rise. The resolutions are agreed to.

[02:12:50] Commending resolutions. Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Madam President, I move the commending resolutions on pages 8 through 10 H.J.R. 81 to S.R. 53 be considered in a block by voice vote, waiving the reading of the resolutions, the understanding any senator desiring resolution from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the resolution.

[02:13:08] The question is, shall the commending resolutions on pages 8-10, H.J.R. 81-S.R. 53 be considered in the block by voice vote, waiving the reading of the resolutions with the understanding that any senator desiring a resolution be removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the resolution.

[02:13:32] All in favor of that motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The resolutions are before us in the block. The clerk will read the number of the resolutions. House Joint Resolutions 81, 130, 131.

[02:13:52] Senate Joint Resolutions 103, 104, 106, 107, 112, 114, 115. - Senate Resolution 49, 50, 51, 52, 53.

[02:14:16] - Senator from Eastern Henrique. - Thank you, Madam President. Can Senate Joint Resolution 106 on page nine come out of the block and go by for the week? - Without objection, SJR 106 is out of the block and by for the week.

[02:14:36] The question is, shall the resolutions be agreed to, that is, all resolutions, except for SJR 106 on page 9. All in favor of agreeing to the resolutions will say aye.

[02:14:52] Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The resolutions are agreed to. The Senator from-- Senior Senator from Prince William.

[02:15:16] Inquiry of the clerk. Does that complete our docket? Yes, sir. Is there any other business to come before the Senate? - The chair recognizes the senator from Northern Fairfax. - Thank you, Madam President.

[02:15:32] I rise for a point of personal privilege. - The senator has the floor. - Well for, you know, I rise to speak about an event that happened last week, but not about the event, but about the person who we lost.

[02:15:51] Sincere, born Allah, passed away last week. And he was somebody that, gosh, made a big impact on my life. You know, we do a lot with public policy. We meet people, we get involved with them.

[02:16:07] We advocate, you know, they advocate for issues and sometimes they get into our hearts and souls. And that's what happened for me, getting to know Sincere over the past, I guess, six years, more or less. I carried the earned sentence credit bill back in 2020 when we were in special session over in the science building, you all might remember.

[02:16:32] And through that, I got to know a lot of loved ones, of people who were incarcerated. I got to understand their stories. I got to understand the challenges that they faced. And Sincere was one that really stood out for me. I went to visit him when he was still behind bars and we did a round table of other people who were incarcerated.

[02:16:56] And I got the opportunity to listen and to learn. and then when Governor Northam brought him home through a pardon, he became a member of my family. He called me mom and visited my home and my family welcomed him with open arms.

[02:17:18] He was somebody who was really important to us. But I wanted to tell you a little bit about him as a person 'cause he has a really interesting background and story. He was born in Roxbury, Massachusetts, and was the grandson of the longest serving woman delegate in the General Assembly in Massachusetts.

[02:17:42] She was the first African American woman and served for 30 years. So Sincere, as a kid, grew up in the halls of the Capitol and he understood activism and public policy.

[02:17:57] He understood campaigns and he worked side by side his grandmother and was so proud of the work that she did around social justice and affordable housing and a lot of the things that we on this side of the aisle focus our time on and when he came home he jumped right back into that and he got a job with the reform alliance and is no stranger to our halls he said and i remember when he and angel came home on the same day and angel's up there where he you know we introduced them and we welcomed them with open arms because we know

[02:18:36] that everybody is better than their worst day and through the past four years he came and testified on our legislation he made sure that he was well educated about the issues and he fought for social justice and prison reform and criminal justice reform and i think he made an enormous difference. There are a lot of people in this building who counted him as a friend, and someone that they loved. And this has been an incredibly painful time for many of us.

[02:19:11] Those who are sitting up there, I know his father is watching from Georgia, Darrell Fox. I know that Gloria Fox, former representative in Massachusetts, would be so proud to have seen all that he did. And I think it's important that each of us remember that we are better than our worst day and that even when we have a smile on our face and we act like everything's okay, some of us carry a big burden on our shoulders. And I think that's something that Sincere did.

[02:19:48] I think he felt responsible for all of the people who have been formerly incarcerated to make sure that he showed the best face and gave everybody a reason to believe that reform is possible and you know I'll never forget taking him shopping the day that he got home and getting him to try on a pair of shoes and because I am a mom and have done this so many times with my own children who I've given birth to you know you check their toe and make sure that there's a little bit of wiggle

[02:20:25] room and you make them walk back and forth and that's what that's what i did and he was just like oh my god you're just like you're you're my mom and uh and we we maintained that friendship and that that closeness and it's painful that he was suffering and didn't know how to communicate that and i think when we think about people who were incarcerated when they're teenagers before they have time to fully mature and spend 24 years behind bars that you know we need more resources we need more help for those individuals to help them

[02:21:00] reintegrate into society and I just want to thank all of the people who are sitting up there who gave their hearts to sincere I see Sean I see Chuck I see Sheba I see Shane I see Angel and I know that there are a lot of them who are listening and watching that his life was not in vain that we're going to continue this work and we're gonna keep moving his message on and I just thank the body for letting me impose on your time

[02:21:35] today it was an enormous loss in my life and in many others and I think it needed to be noted that he was an amazing human being thank you madam president thank you senator the chair recognizes is the Senator from King George.

[02:21:58] Thank you, Madam President. Rise for a brief point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. And Madam President, I apologize for trespassing on everybody's time this afternoon. But there's-- sorry. There's just something I want to read to you. We passed a resolution today.

[02:22:14] And it's particularly fitting for Black History Month. And most of you all weren't here several years ago when I escorted a lovely, a lovely elderly lady this center hall and she got a center our presentation by the name of Gladys May West only a few of us so I just want to read a little bit about this it's Senate Joint Resolution 101 and go back and read it later because she was a very significant person in a in in the world's history quite frankly bear with

[02:22:52] me whereas Gladys May West of King George County a pioneering mathematician and renowned scientist whose groundbreaking achievements transformed global navigation by laying the foundation for the modern satellite-based global positioning system died on January 17, 2026.

[02:23:13] Let me translate that. She developed GPS systems. Pretty amazing. She was a native of Dinwiddie County. She grew up on her parents' tobacco farm and demonstrated an aptitude for mathematics from a very young age.

[02:23:32] She graduated as valedictorian of her segregated high school and earned a full scholarship to what is now Virginia State University. She then went on and earned a bachelor's and master's degree from VSU and worked as a teacher in Waverly and Martinsville until she went to work at what was then the Naval Proving ground, now the Naval Surface Warfare Center in Dahlgren and King George. She at the time was only one of four black employees at that facility and only the second black woman ever hired. Overcame

[02:24:10] significant prejudice and discrimination and distinguished herself through her work, ethic, precision, and commitment to excellence. She was inducted into the United States Air Force hall of fame she received awards in london and across the world for the work that she did and i said at the time when i she was just really sweet lady she's brilliant but she was also really sweet and when i got to talk with her on several occasions but we came in here and i said at the

[02:24:44] time glass ceilings was a proper term that everybody was using and she shattered them all She overcame every obstacle that anybody put in her path, and she became the very best at what she did amongst everyone in the world.

[02:25:01] And I was very sad to lose her this past January. And I just wanted her to be recognized for all the contributions that she has made. Please go read that resolution. I read that much of it, of what she did in her life, and it was really, really significant.

[02:25:17] Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Washington. Thank you, Madam President. Rise for an announcement. Senator has the floor. Madam President, members of the Senate, I hope everyone will join us this afternoon for the third rural caucus of the session.

[02:25:35] The rural caucus will meet at 5 p.m. in the ninth floor meeting room of the GAB. Today's rural caucus meeting, we'll hear from the Honorable Jessica Luman, Virginia Secretary of Labor, as well as my good friend, Tony McDowell, who is the executive director of the opioid abatement authority.

[02:25:51] This marks the second to last meeting of the session, so we hope to see you there. Thank you, Senator. The clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Today, Thursday, February 19th, the Committee on Transportation will meet 15 minutes after adjournment, Senate Room B, GAB.

[02:26:13] The Education and Health Subcommittee on Public Education will meet 30 minutes after adjournment in Senate Room C, GAB. The Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Education will meet at 3 p.m. Senate Finance and Appropriations Room, 13th Floor, GAB.

[02:26:30] The Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Resources will not meet. The Rural Caucus will meet at 5:00 p.m. in House Room 900, 9th Floor, GAB. Tomorrow, Friday, February the 20th, the Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Capital Outlay and Transportation will not meet.

[02:26:49] The Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services will meet at 8:00 a.m., Senate Room A, GAB. The Education and Health Subcommittee on Health Professions will meet at 8:30 a.m. in Senate Room 300, GAB.

[02:27:05] The Committee on Privileges and Elections will meet jointly with the House Privileges and Elections at 9:30 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB. The Democratic Caucus will meet 45 minutes before session in Senate Room 1 of the Capitol.

[02:27:21] The Republican Caucus will meet 30 minutes before session in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. the senior senator from Prince William thank you madam president rise for just one quick announcement senator has the floor to add on to the center from King George there is a sign-on form for Gladys Mae West to sign on to that memorial resolution just amazing I know some got to sign on but please sign on if you don't it's circulating as having a daughter in mathematics and astrophysics it is still very difficult for women in mathematics and she truly

[02:27:56] was a pioneer and just an amazing Virginian so I appreciate that sign on for this historic Virginian and just one moment Madam President. Thank you Senator. The Senator from Western Henrica.

[02:28:13] Thank you Madam President. Madam President Nilsmith. Senator has the floor. Let's make public education 15 minutes on adjournment and not 30. There's no time like now guys.

[02:28:30] Senator from Prince William. Madam President, I'd ask that we recess for approximately half hour until 2:30 p.m., and we will come back after that.

[02:28:47] Without objection, the Senate will be at recess until 2:30 p.m. Madam President. Senator from Hanover. While my Democratic friends are talking amongst their selves, if my Republican friends could join me downstairs.

[03:01:31] Return to order. The senior senator from Prince William.

[03:01:47] President, I move that we adjourn and we do so. We do so in the memory of Gladys Mae West until 10 tomorrow. The question is, shall the Senate adjourn until 10 a.m. tomorrow? And as we do so, we do it in the memory of Gladys Mae West. All in favor of that motion, we'll say aye.

[03:02:12] Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The Senate stands adjourn until

[03:02:18] 12 10 a.m. tomorrow be sure to stay connected with live sessions catch up on past meetings

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[03:04:22] is the senate of virginia richmond virginia chamber



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